

Cypsiurus parvus

African palm swift



Length 5½–6½ in
(14–16 cm)

Weight ¾–¾ oz
(10–18 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location Africa,
Madagascar



Fan palms are the preferred nesting site of this medium-sized, blackish brown swift, although it will use other palms (as well as artificial sites such as bridges). The nest (seen below) is a pad of feathers and plant fibers, glued with saliva to the vertical side of a drooping palm frond, and the eggs themselves are glued in place with saliva. Nestlings have long claws, helping them cling on as the nest blows about in the wind.

Cypseloides niger

American black swift



Length 7–8 in
(18–20 cm)

Weight 1½ oz (45 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Least concern

Location W. North
America, Central America,
Caribbean



A typical, sooty black swift, with long, pointed wings and a slightly forked tail, this fast flier often soars on outstretched wings. Like other swifts, it spends most of its time in the air, and flocks are often seen wheeling through the skies, foraging for insects. Only when breeding does it come down to the ground. Choosing a site next to a waterfall or running water, it builds a half-cup nest formed of living plants—mosses and liverworts—held together with mud.

Aegotheles cristatus

Australian owlet-nightjar



Length 8½–10 in
(21–25 cm)

Weight 1¼–2¾ oz
(35–65 g)

Plumage Sexes differ

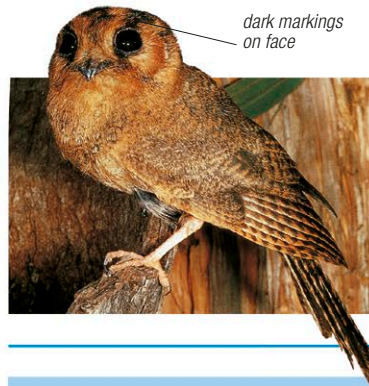
Migration Nonmigrant

Status Least concern

Location S. New Guinea,
Australia (including
Tasmania)



This tree-dwelling bird is a small, nocturnal insect-eater that looks very much like a miniature owl. Compared to other owlet-nightjars, it has well-developed feet and legs, and a long, slender tail. There are distinctive dark markings on its face and head. The barred plumage is gray in the male and brown in the female. The Australian owlet-nightjar is an acrobatic flier, with short, round wings permitting it to make brief foraging flights from its perch to capture insects, either on the ground or in the air. It is preyed upon by mammals and monitor lizards.



dark markings
on face

*Hemiprocne longipennis*Gray-rumped
treeswift

Length 9 in
(23 cm)

Weight Not recorded

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



There are 4 species of treeswifts that belong to a separate family from all other “true” swifts. All of them are found in southern Asia. Like a true swift, the gray-rumped treeswift catches insects on the wing, but it spends less of its time in the air. Between bouts of feeding, it perches on branches—something that true swifts are unable to. This species has long, scythelike wings and a deeply forked tail, but its most distinctive feature is a short, upright crest, attached not to its crown, but to the base of the upper part of its bill. The gray-rumped treeswift makes a minute nest glued to a branch, and lays a single egg. The parents take turns to incubate the egg, covering the nest completely while resting their weight on the branch beneath. Often found in small flocks, nesting pairs of this bird are known to defend their territories aggressively.

Apus apus

Common swift



Length 6½–7 in
(16–17 cm)

Weight 1¼–1¾ oz
(35–50 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Least concern

Location N. and southern
Africa, Europe, W. to
C. Asia



One of the most aerial of birds, the common swift feeds, mates, and even sleeps on the wing. Its nest is a cup-shaped platform formed from plants and feathers that are caught in midair and glued with saliva. It originally nested on rock crevices but now often uses manmade structures. In cold weather, parents often fly hundreds of miles away from the nest. The young survive by becoming torpid; they revive when it warms up, and the parents return with food. After leaving the nest, young swifts remain airborne for up to 3 years, before landing to breed

ON THE WING



Small, noisy groups of these gregarious birds are often seen feeding and moving over towns. Like other swifts, they are fast and agile, turning in flight by beating each wing at a different rate.

stiff, blade-like
wings



themselves. They spend a relatively short time at their summer breeding grounds.

*Hirundapus caudacutus*White-throated
needletail

Length 8½ in
(Up to 21 cm)

Weight Not recorded

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Least concern

Location C., E., and
S.E. Asia, E. Australia



Needletails get their name from their tail feathers, which have spiny tips projecting beyond the end of the feathers. There are 4 species, and all of them are extremely fast fliers, reaching speeds of 125 kph (80 mph) during their spectacular courtship displays. The white-throated needletail lives in small flocks or larger groups, and feeds in all kinds of habitats, including farmland and towns. This bird often feeds near the ground, but it also soars high up, catching insects that are sucked high into the sky by columns of rising warm air. The white-throated needletail breeds in Asia and the Himalayas, and builds a shallow, cup-shaped nest in rocky crevices or hollow trees. In the autumn, this bird migrates south across the equator, reaching as far as Tasmania.

Chaetura pelagica

Chimney swift



Length 4¾–6 in
(12–15 cm)

Weight 1¼–7/8 oz
(19–25 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Near threatened

Location E. North
America, N.W. South
America



This small, smoky brown swift is the only one that breeds in eastern North America. It builds a small, half-cup nest of twigs glued together with saliva, mostly in manmade structures such as chimneys and old barns. When not breeding, chimney swifts roost in large flocks; just before and during migration, several thousand birds might roost together. Large chimneys are a favorite roosting site, and birds pour into them at dusk.

*Collocalia esculenta*

Glossy swiftlet



Length Up to 4¾ in
(11.5 cm)

Weight Not recorded

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern

Location C., E., and
S.E. Asia, E. Australia



Also known as the white-bellied swiftlet, this highly acrobatic flier is one of a small group of species that nest in caves, often

in colonies many thousands strong. It makes its nest entirely from dried saliva, produced by its extra-large salivary glands. Like other swifts, its diet consists of airborne insects, and it is most often seen over forests and gorges, swooping after its prey. In some parts of Southeast Asia, swiftlet nests are harvested, and are used to make birds' nest soup.

